

Preface to the Third Edition

This is probably the final edition of a work begun some twenty years ago and intended then, as now, to fill a gap in the range of texts devoted to the history of psychology. One cannot undertake such a project without experiencing an odd mixture of respect for and disappointment with others who have written books of this kind, and I suspect that some of those others have had similar reactions to earlier editions of this work. There is ample room here for differences in emphasis and interpretation, and for differences in authors' estimations of the importance or relevance or staying-power of specific perspectives and methods.

In my own case, it seemed fairly clear to me years ago, and seems still clearer now, that the general outlines for a systematic psychology were drawn in Hellenic and Hellenistic Greece. If there is a defensible sense in which all philosophy, as Whitehead said, is a footnote to Plato, much in the history of psychology is a footnote to Aristotle. If this is not entirely obvious at the present time it is only because of the reluctance of contemporaries to attempt to absorb the moral and political dimensions of life into current theories and approaches. The reluctance itself is based on the well-formed habit of treating psychology as a natural science (this, too, another debt to Aristotle) but then conceiving of science as an enterprise far more constricted in its aims and methods than was Aristotle's own science.

If the general outlines of the discipline were drawn by ancient Greek philosophers and scientists, the more specific and detailed features were bequeathed by the century of Bacon, Newton, Galileo, and Descartes. It was to these figures that Locke would turn, as would the eighteenth-century *philosophes* and other luminaries of the Enlightenment so convinced that a science of the mind was within reach. By the time the methodology caught up with the metaphysics in the nineteenth century, the essential character of what we take to be "modern psychology" was in place. Thus do we continue to prosecute the agenda of

nineteenth-century psychology. If behaviorism or the "cognitive revolution" or the psychobiological perspective seems new, it is only because we have forgotten or never learned the history of the subject. Failing in this respect, we run the risk of entering the same blind alleys that halted progress in an earlier time. Political and social history are not prophetic, for political and social events are unique and essentially nonrecurring. But intellectual history *is* prophetic. A poorly constructed argument leading to doubtful or distracting conclusions will retain these properties in any and every incarnation. I undertook the first and later editions of this work to put before the reader the main arguments and conclusions that guided psychological thought during the major epochs of Western intellectual history. It is the reader's task to judge which of them is sound and summoning, and which may be no more than distracting or even fallacious.

It is with deep appreciation that I acknowledge the uncommon support provided by the University of Wisconsin. I can only hope that Allen Fitchen's confidence in this and earlier editions has been redeemed. The editorial assistance so generously given by Elizabeth Steinberg and the close and thoughtful editing by Sylvan Esh have improved the book in scores of ways. Its remaining faults are all mine.

Twenty years ago I was indebted to my wife and dearest friend, Francine, for the atmosphere of love and warmth she created for us both. This book, like its author, is dedicated to her.

1 Philosophical Psychology